

Spitting fire and brimstone and promising revolutionary change, the feisty Mamata Banerjee takes on the Marxists in her high-decibel campaign

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

She is both sound and jury. Wherever she is, noise follows, and for those who care to listen and agree, she is the harbingers of change. Trinamool Congress leader Mamata Banerjee had vowed in 2004: "Now or never!" In a matter of five years, she has chosen to forget her slogan. So what if her party had won only one seat, and that too South Kolkata, her backyard? This time, it's only the "Now!" that resonates and Banerjee seems smugly confident, justified by the quite uncharacteristic petty battle cries of her one and only enemy—the CPI(M).

Banerjee moves with a feral felicity, getting down from her borrowed Santro, moving quickly on to a unhooded jeep, finishing her small talk in a matter of seconds, refusing to take to the makeshift rostrum nearby as she is late and hoping that the people would of course understand, urging her followers to move on and not forgetting to utter her by-now famous couplets in Urdu. Longish Tagore and Vivekananda quotes, in correct diction and almost proper context, are reserved for live but rehearsed television shows and interviews.

The Thakurpukur-Maheshtala area in South Kolkata has a smattering of Muslims and at one point, as the jeep comes to a halt, a man jostles his way to her and gives her an *urnee*, which she most fondly and with careful worship wears like a traditional Muslim woman. "I am so happy that you have given me this *urnee*. I do not take gifts from all and sundry. And, of course, I am not going to talk politics in front of a mosque. I have one *urnee* at home and I make it a point to wear

it after I break roza on Holy Ramzaan," she tells the crowd.

Banerjee will move to North Kolkata after this and it's time she set the pace. "This area was in my Jadavpur constituency the first time I contested the Lok Sabha elections in 1984. Since then, it has been my dream to return here. After I was almost killed by the CPI(M) in 1990, Rajiv Gandhi asked me to contest from a smaller constituency since I was unable to move around for

long stretches and thus I shifted to South Kolkata. But see the delimitation process has brought this area under South Kolkata this time and it is indeed a dream come true for me. I don't know whether I will be able to return to you before the elections. But I will, once you allow me to win again. That's a promise," Banerjee says softly.

Then the tone changes. "I will travel throughout Bengal as I have to. But let me tell you this. I will not be

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